PRIMARY TEACHING NOTES SERIES

Pedagogy for Primary Teachers

How young children actually learn, and how a teacher's choices — what to ask, when to help, how to practise and how to check — turn a lesson into real learning.

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These are study and practice notes for primary teachers, written in simple English. They cover one topic only — pedagogy, the art and science of teaching children — and follow the themes taught in teacher induction training: learning principles, child-centred teaching, questioning, differentiation, assessment and reflective practice.

What Pedagogy Means

Every teacher uses methods — explaining, questioning, group work, practice on slates. Pedagogy is the thinking behind those methods: why you chose this activity, for these children, at this moment, and how you will know if it worked. Two teachers can use the same textbook page and teach completely different lessons. The difference is pedagogy.

> **Plain idea:** Pedagogy means the art and science of teaching children. *Art*, because it needs judgement, warmth and timing. *Science*, because it rests on what we know about how children learn.

Pedagogy is not the same as a method

- **A method** is one technique: a demonstration, a drill, a story, a group task.
- **Pedagogy** is the whole set of decisions around it: the goal, the starting point, the examples, the questions, the support, the practice and the check at the end.
- **Curriculum** says *what* to teach. Pedagogy decides *how* this class will actually learn it.

Pedagogy and andragogy

In induction books you will also meet the word *andragogy* — teaching adults. Adults learn best from their experience, at their own pace, for a clear purpose. Children are different: they need more guidance, more activity, shorter steps, and a teacher who builds their confidence as well as their knowledge. That is why primary teaching is a special skill, not an easier version of teaching older students.

A good test of pedagogy

At the end of a lesson, do not only ask, "Did I finish the topic?" Ask, "What can the children do now that they could not do at the start — and how do I know?" Pedagogy lives in the second question.

Principles of Good Primary Pedagogy

Different books list these principles in different words, but the core ideas stay the same. Keep them in mind when you plan any lesson, in any subject.

1. Start from what the child already knows

New learning sticks when it joins old learning. Begin with two or three questions about yesterday's lesson or daily life — counting stones before counting in tens, home words before textbook words.

2. Learning is active, not poured in

Children remember what they do, say and try far better than what they only hear. In every period, children should talk, write, sort, draw, count or solve — not only listen.

3. Small steps, in the right order

Break a skill into steps a young child can succeed at: first with the teacher, then with a partner, then alone. Success in a small step gives courage for the next one.

4. Practice makes it stay

Understanding in the lesson is not enough. Short, regular practice — today, tomorrow, next week — is what moves learning into long memory.

5. Feedback, not just marks

A child improves when told exactly what was right and what to fix next: "Your addition is correct; now line up the tens under the tens." A tick or a cross alone teaches nothing.

6. Safety and respect come first

Children learn from teachers they trust. A child who fears being laughed at stops answering, guessing and trying — and stops learning in public.

> **Remember:** the child is not an empty vessel and the lesson is not water. Teaching is building — and the child must hold some of the bricks.

Thinkers Who Help Teachers

Induction books name many thinkers. You do not need their full theories — you need the one practical idea each one gives a primary teacher.

Jean Piaget — children think in stages

Piaget showed that young children do not think like small adults. Primary-age children (about 7 to 11) learn best with real things they can touch, sort and see — stones, sticks, pictures, number lines — before abstract symbols. A child who cannot yet do a sum in his head may do it easily with counters. That is not weakness; it is the stage.

Lev Vygotsky — learning grows with help

Vygotsky gave teachers two lasting ideas. The **zone of proximal development** is the gap between what a child can do alone and what the same child can do with a little help. Teaching should aim inside that zone — not so easy it bores, not so hard it breaks confidence. **Scaffolding** is that help: a hint, a worked example, a partner, a word bank — given at first, then slowly removed as the child grows able.

Benjamin Bloom — levels of thinking

Bloom arranged thinking from simple to deep: remember, understand, apply, analyse, evaluate, create. A lesson that only asks children to remember will produce children who only remember. Add one higher step: apply the rule in a new sum, explain why, or make an example of your own.

Thinker	One idea to keep	In your classroom
Piaget	Thinking grows in stages	Concrete objects before abstract work
Vygotsky	Help inside the zone, then remove it	Hints, partners and examples as scaffolds
Bloom	Thinking has levels	Move from recall to using and creating

> **Simple rule:** concrete first, help at the right moment, and questions that climb — that is three famous theories turned into one teaching habit.

Child-Centred and Activity-Based Learning

In a teacher-centred lesson, the teacher talks and the class listens for most of the period. In a child-centred lesson, the teacher still leads — but the children do the learning work: talking in pairs, handling materials, solving, reading and making.

What child-centred really means

- The **goal** is still set by the teacher and the curriculum. Child-centred does not mean children choose anything they like.
- The **activity** is built around the child: her age, language, experience and pace.
- The **teacher** becomes a guide — demonstrating, questioning, helping groups, and noticing who is stuck.

Activity-based learning in practice

- **Play and games** in early grades: sorting, matching, counting games and role play teach language, number and social skills together.
- **Learning by doing:** measure the classroom with hand spans before learning metres; plant a seed before reading about how plants grow.
- **Talk for learning:** "Tell your partner how you solved it" makes thinking visible — children learn from each other's words, not only the teacher's.
- **Choice in small doses:** choose which two questions to answer first, or draw or write your answer. Small choice builds ownership.

Activity is not noise for its own sake. Every activity must point at the lesson goal, and the teacher closes it by naming what was learned: "Today we found that..." Without that closing step, children remember the fun and forget the learning.

> **Balance:** explain clearly, then let children work actively, then bring the class together to fix and name the learning. Tell — do — review. That rhythm fits almost any primary lesson.

Questioning, Talk and Feedback

Questions are the teacher's steering wheel. They start thinking, reveal misunderstanding, and pull quiet children into the lesson.

Two kinds of questions

- **Closed questions** have one short answer: "What is 7 + 5?" Good for checking facts and warming up.
- **Open questions** need thinking and sentences: "How did you solve it? Is there another way?" Good for understanding and talk.

A strong lesson uses both — closed questions to check, open questions to grow.

Habits that make questioning work

- **Wait time:** ask, then wait silently for three to five seconds. Hands rise slowly; thinking takes time, especially in a second language.
- **No hands up, sometimes:** choose who answers after everyone has thought, so the whole class thinks — not only the fastest five.
- **Pair talk first:** let children rehearse an answer with a partner before speaking to the class. Shy children speak far more this way.
- **Follow the answer:** "Why do you think so?" and "Who can add to that?" turn one answer into real discussion.
- **Wrong answers are information:** never mock or rush past them. A wrong answer shows exactly where to re-teach.

Feedback children can use

Good feedback is fast, specific and kind: name what is correct, name the one next step, and let the child try again at once. Praise effort and strategy — "You checked your work, that is why it is right" — more than fixed labels like "clever boy", which make children fear the next mistake.

> **Try this:** in tomorrow's lesson, ask fewer questions — but wait longer, let partners talk first, and follow two answers with "why?" Depth beats speed.

Every Child Can Learn: Differentiation and Inclusion

In one primary class, some children read fluently and some are still joining sounds. Teaching everyone in exactly the same way, at the same pace, with the same task, guarantees that the weakest are lost and the strongest are bored. Differentiation answers this without needing three separate lessons.

> **Plain idea:** Differentiation means keeping the same learning goal for all, but changing the support, the task or the time so every child can reach it — and the strongest can go further.

Three easy ways to differentiate

- **By support:** word banks, sentence starters, counters, a worked example, or five minutes with the teacher's table group.
- **By task:** a core task for all, a helping task below it, and a challenge task above it — "finish, then try this one."
- **By outcome and time:** accept a drawing and labels from one child and a full paragraph from another, both showing the same understanding.

Inclusion is pedagogy, not kindness extra

- Seat a child with weak sight or hearing near the front, and check understanding privately, not by public testing.
- Use pictures, gestures and real objects alongside words, so a child weak in the language of the textbook can still enter the lesson.
- Never use a child's difficulty as an example, a joke or a punishment. Dignity is a condition for learning.
- Pair thoughtfully: a patient, kind partner helps a struggling child far more than isolation at the back.

Differentiation is mostly planned in two minutes before the lesson: Who will find this hard? What will I give them? Who will finish early? What will stretch them? Those two questions are pedagogy in action.

Assessment as Part of Pedagogy

Many teachers meet assessment only as exams and marks. In good pedagogy, assessment is something smaller and far more useful: the teacher checking, during learning, whether learning is happening — and changing the lesson when it is not.

Two kinds of assessment

- **Formative assessment** happens *during* learning: questions, slate work held up for the teacher to scan, a quick exit question, watching children practise. Its job is to guide the next step.
- **Summative assessment** happens *at the end*: the term test or final exam. Its job is to report what was learned.

Both matter, but formative assessment is the one that improves learning while there is still time. A test after the chapter cannot help the child who was lost in week one.

Low-cost formative tools

- **Slates and mini-boards:** every child shows an answer at once — the teacher sees thirty answers in ten seconds.
- **Thumbs check:** up for "I understand", sideways for "partly", down for "lost" — followed by pair help before re-teaching.
- **Exit question:** one question in the last three minutes decides tomorrow's starting point.
- **Mark with the child:** read answers together and let children correct their own work in a different colour. Correction is learning, not cheating.

Use what you find

Checking is wasted if nothing changes. If half the class is wrong, re-teach differently — with an example, a drawing or counters — instead of repeating the same explanation louder. If only three children are lost, help those three while the class practises.

> **Rule of thumb:** never end a lesson you have not checked, and never start a new topic on top of an old one the class has not understood.

Pedagogy in Real Primary Classrooms

Books often describe small, rich classrooms. Many government primary teachers face forty or more children, few materials, two grades in one room, and children who speak a home language different from the textbook. Good pedagogy does not wait for perfect conditions — it adapts.

Large classes

- Use pair and group work as extra teachers: children explaining to each other multiplies help you cannot give alone.
- Check with slates, thumbs and sampling — look carefully at six books per period, rotating, instead of thirty books badly.
- Train routines and class monitors, so your energy goes to teaching, not to managing queues and materials.

Multigrade classes

- Teach one grade directly while the other does a clear, self-running practice task, then swap. Pedagogy here is planning two honest activities, not one.
- Use shared openings: a story, a number talk or a picture can start both grades, then split into grade-level tasks.

Language in the classroom

Where children think in Pashto or Urdu and learn from English or Urdu textbooks, let talk begin in the language children own, then bridge to the textbook language with key words on the board. Understanding first, language growing with it — a child silent in the wrong language is not a child without ideas.

The reflective teacher

Pedagogy improves through reflection: two honest minutes after a lesson. What worked? Who was lost? What will I change tomorrow? Teachers who keep this habit — in a notebook or even in mind — grow faster than teachers who only repeat years. Induction is the start of learning to teach, not the end of it.

Pedagogy Checklist and Quick Revision

Use this checklist when you plan tomorrow's lesson. It turns the ideas in these notes into two minutes of honest questions.

My lesson checklist

- I know the one goal of the lesson — what children will be able to do at the end.
- I start from what the children already know.
- Children will do, talk, practise or make — not only listen.
- The steps are small, ordered, and begin with real things or examples.
- My questions include "how" and "why", not only recall.
- I have planned wait time and partner talk before public answers.
- Help is ready for children who will struggle, and a challenge for those who finish.
- I will check learning during the lesson, not only at the end.
- My feedback will name what is right and the one next step.
- Every child will be treated with dignity, especially when wrong.

Five points to remember

1. Pedagogy is the thinking behind methods — why this activity, for these children, now.
2. Learning is active: start from prior knowledge, use small steps, practise, and give usable feedback.
3. Piaget, Vygotsky and Bloom in plain form: concrete first, scaffold inside the zone, and questions that climb.
4. Child-centred teaching keeps the teacher's goal but puts children to work — tell, do, review.
5. Differentiation, formative assessment and reflection make pedagogy work for every child, in real classrooms.

A method can be copied in a day. Pedagogy grows over a career — lesson by lesson, class by class, whenever a teacher asks not only "Did I teach it?" but "Did they learn it, and how do I know?"